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Ronnie Zito

Utica, New York native Ronnie Zito has led a varied career as a drummer for Bobby Darin, the Woody Herman Orchestra, for numerous Broadway productions, and as a first-call musician for New York jazz gigs and studio work.

Ronnie was interviewed via Zoom on March 9, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive, and Rick Montalbano, longtime friend of Ronnie and a previous interviewee of the Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Ronnie Zito with me today along with my good pal Rick Montalbano. We are in three different places, musically I like to think we're closer together.

RZ: Yeah.

MR: So you're still playing "Chicago" I guess.

RZ: Yeah, 25 years I've been playing it. So it's still going. You know we closed for Covid for quite a while you know, like a year and a half. And then we went back, you know, they were trying to get New York going, there's more people in New York now, you know, people are coming back. So it's a good band, you know, it's like a 13-piece band all good players, all great players you know. One of the trumpet players is the trumpet player on Saturday Night Live, Earl Gardner, great cat man. And anyway that's what I've been doing.

RM: Ronnie, at what point does the band join, start rehearsing with the show? Where is the show at when you bring the band in?

RZ: Well the band doesn't come in, I'll rehearse with a piano player and a conductor you know. They do it that way, which is a drag. No bass.

RM: Oh no kidding?

RZ: But I mean it's all technical as far as start/stop/start with the cast. You know it's mostly start/stop for the cast. You know and then they'll add things, they'll change things in the music sometimes. But the band doesn't come in until — the whole band doesn't start rehearsing until maybe five or six days before the first performance.

RM: Oh really.

RZ: Yeah. So you know that's the way that goes.

RM: And are the guys coming in and just sight reading at that point?

RZ: No, no. Some of the guys, well actually a lot of guys are sight reading because I'm one of the only originals, me and two other people from 25 years ago. I'm one of the only ones. Just, there are three of us that are the original orchestra members. But yeah, new guys

come in and you know it's quite a process you know, what they go through, as far as preparing everyone you know.

MR: Ronnie, years ago Utica has a sort of Broadway Theater League, and "Cats" came to town. And I happened to meet one of the keyboard players and he said, "Why don't you come and sit in the pit" for one of the shows. So I did. And it's the first time I'd seen that close up, and when they had done their parts then the keyboard player hits a couple of buttons on his Prophet 5 and then he gets out the magazine or the book and he starts reading. And everybody's doing that.

RZ: Not me.

MR: That's my question. How do you keep focused?

RZ: That's the main, man, the focusing is the main thing. It's like — it's — that's the problem. You have to keep focusing. But with me I have so much to do — I'm playing drums, I'm playing percussion, I'm playing some orchestra bells, I'm jumping around a lot you know. We're on stage. We can see the show. But that's like I have to just keep focused man. If I start wandering and thinking about like something else, getting my car fixed or something, man you know four bars go by and I say oops, where am I. You know how that is. Rick, you know. Oh Rick, how's your son, man?

RM: Yeah he's doing well.

RZ: I talked to Frank DeVito last week and we were talking about him and it's great man. I know he's a wonderful player.

RM: I had always hoped when he first went to New York that I could hook him up with you.

RZ: Oh I'm out in Jersey here.

RM: Yeah somehow it didn't work out with school and then he started playing right away.

RZ: Yeah, oh that's great. Well I work in New York but as soon as I'm done I drive back home 20 miles away I'm in a very residential area, a beautiful little town, Oradell, New Jersey. And I've got a great wife, Patricia. She helps me all the time you know.

MR: So Ronnie, I was looking this morning at the top ten from different years, and if my calculations are right when you were ten years old the top singers in the music were Perry Como, Frankie Laine, Dinah Shore. Okay. Six years later "Cherry Pink and Apple Blossom White," "Rock Around the Clock," "The Yellow Rose of Texas." So my question is, what on the radio, if anything, grabbed you at that time, when you were like impressionable?

RZ: Oh man. Well I'll tell you the truth, I wasn't into a lot of pop music at all. My brother, my older brother Torrie, Torrie Zito, he was into jazz. He was a piano player. And I used to listen to his records. He would buy records and I would just zero in. But there were some pop records that I really liked. You know like — oh I mean well actually it was rhythm and blues bands. That's what it was you know. It was really rhythm and blues.

You know like Wilson Pickett and those people in the beginning, I just loved the rhythm feel you know in those records. But yeah "Rock Around the Clock" and those, they were okay but it was more like it just struck me as being like country you know, more country than anything else. But I know the people just loved it. But that's about it. I listened to a lot of jazz records when I was like 14 and 15, I was listening to Miles and you know, all that, Bud Powell.

MR: But you were playing gigs around Central New York and the Utica area probably early on.

RZ: Well I got a gig in Syracuse at Three Rivers Inn.

MR: Dominick Bruno.

RZ: Pardon me?

RM: Dominick Bruno's place.

RZ: Oh yeah. Yeah. And Tony Riposo was the leader and he hired me and at the time I had not much experience playing for acts. And they had big names coming in, you know, Tony Bennett and Sammy Davis, all these people. And I didn't play for every one. I mean you know most of the big guys had their own rhythm section you know, so I might sit out. But then there were other people that came in like the Mills Brothers, you know, the Maguire Sisters, Four Lads, I would play for them. And it was great experience. And Tony Riposo was the leader. And when I went in there my reading was not — I mean I was about 17 or 18 you know. And my reading was like I told Tony, I says, "Man," I said, "I don't know about my reading." I mean I read music in high school you know, in band, in the band room and concerts. But that was more classical. But Tony said, "Don't worry about it, don't worry about it." I don't know if you knew Tony well, Rick.

RM: Yeah. Yeah. He was great.

RZ: And he said, "Don't worry about it, I'll get you through this." Because Tony just wanted me on the gig because he was a terrific jazz player.

RM: He sure was.

RZ: And he just wanted to blow. He wanted to play on the dance sets.

RM: Right

RZ: You know he wanted to swing. He wanted to play, and he liked the way I played that you know. That's kind of how I got the gig. But then he started literally teaching me how to read. You know he'd say, he'd grab a piece of music and he'd say, "Take a look at this," he goes — or before he would say take a look at it, he'd say, "Can you sing [scats]?" "Can you sing that?" And I would go [scats]. And then Tony would point at the paper and say, "Well that's what you just sang. It's on the paper." He said, "You can do this, you just sang it. If you can sing it, you've got a good chance of playing it." And it was like

that. It was no pressure. He never pressured me or anything like that. Tony Riposo, great musician.

RM: His brother Joe is still around.

RZ: Oh wow. Say hello please.

RM: Alto player.

RZ: Yeah.

MR: Did you ever have any acts that came into Three Rivers, the actual singers for instance, like tell you to do something different, or give you one of those looks like this is not what we want?

RZ: Oh they might ask, but usually they talked to the conductor about something like that. And then it might come to me. The conductor will say, "Ronnie at Letter B they want a more quarter note feel" or something like that. Cross-stick or something like that. It was, they never addressed the musicians most of the time you know. It was that type thing.

MR: Were you a big deal, did you go to UFA?

RZ: Yeah.

MR: Okay so I'm imagining that you were a big deal. "Ronnie has a gig."

RZ: You know it's funny, my family was, the Zito name was a big deal because my brothers went to that school and they'd say, "Oh Ronnie Zito's coming in, we're going to get another Zito." And that would put me under pressure man. I'd be like oh no, because I was the youngest you know. And it was great, it was great. We had great music teachers. Ed Hacker, a great, great guy. As a matter of fact I was playing like one of the — someone paged me at the stage door after the show "Chicago" and I go to the stage door man, and it's Ed Hacker — my old high school teacher. "Ronnie, oh I'm so proud of you." You know I said, "Wow I can't believe this." Ed Hacker.

RM: Ronnie, did you study with the drum teacher that Jimmy Wormworth did, Babe something?

RZ: No, not Babe Costello, no. It was George Glaskins. That's who we both studied with. It was great man. I mean he didn't know anything about jazz or anything like that, or playing a drumset, but he really, rudimentally, he was wonderful you know. And I still think about him, you know, like the way he did things when I went to his lesson you know, we'd have two practice pads set up and he'd — you know he had a beautiful roll man. I'm still working on that. And I think of him all the time.

MR: So there's a bit of an upstate mystery I'd like to just ask about — there's Nistico, Romano, Esposito, Mancuso, Zito — like what's that about?

RM: You forgot a few, Monk.

MR: I know.

RM: Brignola, Menza.

RZ: Don Menza. Mel Lewis from Buffalo. Mel Lewis. Steve Gadd.

MR: But is there something in the Italian household that you can point to that you know, enabled this wonderful crowd of musicians that came out of Upstate, New York?

RZ: I don't know I think it was more — I think we were all kind of like, it was a brotherly thing. The music made us — gave us a brotherly feel. And it did man. When you run into guys, I would run into guys that I might have just met that night and within twenty minutes we're like tight. You know what I mean? You get that feeling like I've known this guy, we've known each other for a long time. It was that kind of thing.

RM: When did you meet the Mancusos, Ronnie?

RZ: Oh from when I was a kid. The Mancusos were — Sam Mancuso, he was — he knew me from when I was like a young kid, like eight or nine years old. He knew my family, you know, my brothers. And oh, a great musician, man. The Mancusos were just — he was a huge influence on me man. Still, still to this day.

RM: Yeah. I have a couple of recordings of him on guitar.

RZ: Oh, man.

RM: That are —

RZ: Is that beautiful?

RM: Yeah. I mean it was hard to imagine hearing somebody that good.

RZ: I mean you know and the thing about Sammy was you know when he played the guitar, man, he didn't even, he just picked down. Did you know that?

RM: Yeah.

RZ: He picked down. Down-up-down-up. You know.

RM: He had something with I think his fourth finger where he didn't use it or something.

RZ: Yeah. And when he played piano.

RM: The thumbs.

RZ: The thumbs were down. The thumbs were off on the side. I mean he sounded like Horace or somebody.

RM: I would look over his shoulder, I used to go to his house every Saturday morning and we'd have coffee and some donuts, and then him and I would go and play and then eventually Dolores would come in. But he would show me something. Just go here — play this. What is it? It's G minor. And I'd look at it and I said, "That's not G minor. It's G minor sort of but it's got like all these other things. You know, so I had to just kind of, you know, figure out —

RZ: He was so impressive to me man as a person too. Because he had his own house, he had a day gig.

RM: Yeah how about that?

RZ: He was a supervisor in some plant or something. And I just, I think about, there was this respect you know. Because he had more than we all had. I don't mean a lot of money or anything but a way of life. You know what I mean? He just, that was the way I wanted to live. You know, the way Sammy did.

RM: Yes, yes.

MR: I love hearing this and it makes me think about the learning process back then and how it gets passed on. You know Rick passed on that kind of thing to me, and I didn't even have to ask for it. It was just like you said, watching and listening.

RZ: It's there, right? Yeah.

MR: It's so different from how most, now we go to universities to get it.

RZ: Yeah absolutely. You're right, you're right. And there's some great, great schools and there are great programs now, music programs that we didn't have. We didn't have access to it. Rick, I don't know, you know well I mean I'm older than you so, but I don't remember jazz classes and stuff like that.

RM: No books.

RZ: Like it is now, man. You know.

RM: I think there was a book called Bugs Bower.

MR: There was. I remember that name.

RM: And that was the only like information. Like what a God, you know.

RZ: And it was, yeah, valuable, at the time.

RM: Ronnie, your friendship with Jimmy Wormworth, and I want to ask you about the mystery drummer, Gordon.

RZ: Oh Gordon man. Oh man.

RM: Was it Gordon Smith?

RZ: Gordon Smith, yeah. He was about — he passed away young like 27 or something.

RM: Oh my God.

RZ: But Jimmy and I used to go to a club called — one of the clubs —

RM: Minor's?

RZ: Minor's Grill or Wang and Jean's. And it was in the black section, you know. And the music was fantastic. You know you walk in there and it's just great. But the overall feeling was great too in those days. Even as weird as it was then racially and all that, you know, it wasn't that way when we were there. You know it was just the music and everybody having a good time. There was no like tension or any of that. You know. But the music was great and Gordon was usually playing drums. Gordon Smith. And the first time I heard Gordon, oh man, it wasn't there. The first time I heard him was at another gig with Vic Circh. Do you remember Vic Circh?

RM: Vic Circh. I just posted a video it's Sal Amico and myself and JR playing at Bobby's Restaurant and Vic came and he sang and he scatted. Oh my God.

RZ: A natural musician. Natural, man.

RM: My goodness gracious.

RZ: Anyway Gordon was playing and I was about 15 or 16. I think I was with Jimmy. We were just hanging out and it was like I couldn't believe the groove and the imagination, just, and people were dancing. It was like the Vic Circh — you know that rhythm & blues. It was rhythm & blues more than jazz you know, but it was jazz. But Gordon had a way of playing a shuffle and things like that man that to this day when I play the show we play a tune and I just cop that off of Gordon. I just play that shuffle that he played. And I talked to Jimmy about it. I said man, I still play that certain thing with my left hand that he did that was so magical that I went home and worked on it. You know. Like I said I've got to do this.

RM: Right.

RZ: You know? When you hear somebody like that, man, and you feel like oh I've got to get this, I've got to try to do this. You know. It's exciting, man, it's very exciting. Oh he was great man. Gordon Smith. And a great guy man.

MR: When you got tapped to go with Bobby Darin, was there any question about doing it? Did you —

RZ: Oh yeah. I said to Tony, Bobby asked me if I could go with him for six weeks. Right? Or something like that. He didn't say I want you to be my drummer right away. And he says I've got this gig in Washington, DC. So I spoke to Tony about it and Tony says, "Go, man, go ahead. You're young, go ahead, just do it." By that time I was playing, because I was at Three Rivers for about two or three years and I was playing real good, my reading got real good, because you're playing different music every week you know. So your sight reading gets better, so when Bobby came in I just was — it was easy, all I had to do was swing you know. Like he did want to swing. "Mack the Knife" had just come out, it just came out. I didn't even know like how big he was, up in Utica. We didn't really know. When I got to New York it was on the radio constantly you know. And all of a sudden I'm doing The Ed Sullivan Show. You know?

RM: Oh my God.

RZ: So he said, "You've got to get a tux." You know. I had to get a tux and the band, on The Ed Sullivan Show, it was Thad Jones in the trumpet section, his brother Hank Jones playing piano, they were all on staff, CBS staff man. Those guys were like busy in the studios, and a lot of other guys. Great, great players. But after I went with Bobby he asked me to stay with him you know. I did the first gig and he said, "No, you want to stay?" I said okay. I stayed there for four years. I did it for four years with him.

MR: Do you mind me asking what was your weekly salary when you started with him?
RZ: Oh Jeez, with Bobby?
MR: Yeah.
RZ: In those days?
MR: Yeah.
RZ: Oh man it was like, I don't know, 250 a week, something like that you know.
MR: That was pretty good.
RZ: And I thought oh wow, pretty good you know. In those days I mean it was like 1960 or 1959. Something like that.
RM: Ronnie, did you play on "Beyond the Sea" is that you on that record?
RZ: No man, that's — I wish it was. That's Don Lamond, the great Don Lamond man.
RM: Oh my God.
MR: I always wanted to know who did those fills.
RZ: That's Don Lamond. Only Don could do that. He was unbelievable. I got it down though man, when I was with Bobby, I played the same shit man. I practiced it, because I loved it so much that it was one of those things I said I've got to try to play this, I've got to do it. And in those days it was like I don't know man, I was more fearless I think in those days.
RM: Well that recording, the live concert that you're on —
RZ: Oh the Copa?
RM: The Copa.
RZ: Yeah, the Copacabana, yeah.
RM: You talked about my son, he heard that many times man, because I played that recording many times. It's just fantastic, Ronnie.
RZ: It's a good record man, yeah.
RM: As a matter of fact it's hard to even listen to anybody else but you when you listen to that recording. I have to listen to you.
RZ: Well thank you.
RM: I'm like in front listening to the hi-hat and the —
RZ: Oh man, and they weren't even my drums, man. I used to play on the drums, like we used to travel all over and I'd walk in and I would have maybe my own snare drum and that would be it. Everything else, whatever was there I played. And it was fine, it didn't bother me, didn't bother me at all.
MR: Did you like being on the road?
RZ: That's a good question, man. Not particularly. I liked, like when we had some location gigs like in Vegas, we were like maybe two, three weeks.
RM: Right.

RZ: Or in New York at the Copa, we worked there a lot. That was nice because I got to see my brother you know. And actually I saw my wife there. I didn't meet her there but I did see her.

RM: That scene in *Goodfellas* where they walk in.

RZ: Oh, that's it. That's it man. Remember that kitchen? That whole scene. There was a waiter in that scene, he's a real — I remember seeing that guy there.

RM: No kidding.

RZ: Yeah, yeah. I remember that guy, seeing him all the time. Because we were there maybe three, four times a year you know. Because Bobby was hot then.

RM: Boy I'll say.

RZ: He got very popular. So Vegas, you know. But yeah like when I was with Woody's band it was different traveling because we did one nighters. That was rough traveling.

MR: On a bus?

RZ: Yeah on a bus, mostly on a bus. Yeah.

RM: Was Sal Nistico in that band with you?

RZ: Yes, oh yeah man. Sal —

RM: Joe Romano?

RZ: No it wasn't Joe, Joe Farrell was there a while, and then Frank Foster was on the band too. And Bill Chase of course. Great trumpet player. Great players man. Tony Leonardi. I got him on the gig.

RM: Oh no kidding.

RZ: I did. I recommended him. The bass player was leaving and I said, "Get this guy from Syracuse, Tony Leonardi." Nat Pierce was kind of in charge of the band you know.

MR: How did you guys pass your time during all that travel on the bus?

RZ: Oh, we would talk a lot about music and players you know. Like, "Did you hear Freddie Hubbard's last record" or this or that. You know. Then we had a little battery-driven record player on the bus for a while. It was like a little — it was a piece of junk man, I think it was made in Taiwan or something. I don't know. But yeah then we'd sleep. We'd try to sleep man. You know. Because we'd get in at maybe five in the morning and check in man. Leave the gig, you know, get on the bus, try to sleep and then check in at around four or five, depending on how far it was. Then get up and try and get ready for the gig. But it's funny, to me, Woody's band, man, I loved the gigs that we did when we played like gigs in a VFW or something like that. It wasn't even a concert it was just the band was hired to play a dance. Woody took everything. He took every gig. I mean we were doing concerts, big festivals. And then all of a sudden the next day we'd be playing a dance you know. But the band swung. When we played for dancing man, it was just great you know. I always loved playing for dancing.

RM: I don't think that's an experience young jazz players get these days.

RZ: No.

RM: Coming out of the colleges. We were talking about everybody coming out like every year another ten thousand great players come out.

RZ: Yeah.

RM: But gigs, the kind that we used to play you know.

MR: Yeah recently I was trying to describe, okay when you're playing for dancers you might start out with a two-beat, and then you get going, and then you go into swing. And they're looking at me like what is this? Did you get to a point, you are a young man, did you ever think about the future? Like do I want to settle down? Am I looking for something that's going to put me in one place like studio work etcetera?

RZ: Yeah well I met my wife and we got married in '65. And that's when I left Woody's band. She's fantastic. I mean she like, saves my life you know. And actually when we got married, I've got to tell you this story if you don't mind, I told Woody I was going to get married. He goes, "You what? You're what?" We're sitting on a counter in a coffee shop. He says, "You're getting married, what? Are you kidding?" I said, "Yeah, we're getting married." I said, "We've got to set a date" you know. And he says, "Oh, you can't get married on that day," he says, "we have a big gig with Tony Bennett." He says, "You've got to do it, you've got to do it. Tony Bennett is on the concert" you know. And he says, "But I'll give you a couple of days off before, I'll give you a couple of days off before if we can get this drummer from Texas" or something I don't know. Paul Guerrera was his name, yeah, I remember. And so anyway we got married that day and we had a reception and now I've got to go to the gig. I've got to leave the reception to go to the gig. I still had my jacket on. I think I rented a white jacket. And we leave the place and my wife has a gown on yet and we jump in the car and we go to the gig, which was about three, four miles away from the reception where we were. And we walk in and I just run down the aisle and jump behind the drums you know. And then Tony introduces my wife, she is sitting in the back. "Stand up," you know, he made a big deal out of it, that we just, you know. And of course my brother was writing for Tony, wrote some good arrangements for him.

RM: He sure did. And for Frank.

RZ: Yeah. Oh I miss him man. He was my brother.

RM: So Ronnie, tell me how many musicians were in your family?

RZ: Well my father, Artie. My brother Freddie, who was on every band in the world man. He left Utica when he was about 20. He was on Stan Kenton's band and Charlie Barnet, all the bands. And that was in the band era you know. And he settled in New York and then he moved to Las Vegas later on. But my father was a musician, my father worked in the

Stanley Theater playing bass in the Stanley Theater Orchestra. Those were the days where they had stage shows and they might show a movie and they'd have a stage show or just stage shows. And my father loved that gig. He loved it. It was like the best gig he could get in Utica you know. I mean in that area at the time. And then it ended and he was destroyed when that ended, man. Then my uncles that were musicians, my uncle Jerry, my uncle Bob, he was a violinist, my uncle Tony was, he just gigged around, he sang and he gigged around with an Irish harp. But he gigged locally around and he did okay. But they used to bill him as Tony Zito the Irish harpist. So I'd say to my father, "What did he do, where did he work?" He says, "Oh he just went busking around" you know, busking around. They used those terms. My uncles were all older. My father was older. Old time. I said, "How did you get to the gig weren't you in Herkimer in the winter?" And my Uncle Jerry would say, "Well it was by cutter." Cutters. I said, "Cutters?" He said, "Sleigh. Horse and sleigh."

RM: Oh my God.

RZ: Yeah. It was like 1902 or something. And I said, "Cutters?" "Sleigh in the snow, yeah oh yeah." I said, "Well what kind of band was it." "Oh harp and violin and maybe some mandolin or something." Like then they played old music man. They played like turn of the century music. And they were older. My father was older and they played like things like Nelson Eddy. Remember Nelson Eddy?

RM: Oh yeah, and Jeanette MacDonald.

RZ: Way back. Yeah. And like Jeanette MacDonald, all those — beautiful music. It was beautiful you know. But that's what they did. Everybody, we always played, there was always something going on. There was a string quartet in the front room. And we lived in a little A frame house. There was no room really, on Seymour Avenue, which is gone now, it's a parking lot. But there was always music happening. You know my brother was always playing or there was a trio or a singer would come in and rehearse tunes with Torrie you know. You remember the Lafayette Lounge in Utica?

RM: Yes.

RZ: Torrie used to do a single there you know, before he ever left Utica. He used to play the piano by himself and accompany singers. All these singers would come in you know.

RM: Well your brother was, you know, amongst the piano players in the area he was like an icon of course.

RZ: Oh he was wonderful man, yeah.

RM: Especially because the story is you could put any piece of music in front of him and he could sight read anything from classical music on down.

RZ: He used to sight read scores man, of classical music.

RM: Oh my God.

RZ: And when he was a kid, when he was about 16, on Sundays he would sit at the kitchen table with the radio on with these scores. He had miniature scores that my uncle gave him of everything: Beethoven, Mozart, you name it. And he would read the scores, you know, like turning the page and listening, listening, listening.

RM: Incredible.

MR: So Ronnie, did you fall into studio work or was it like I want to get in the studio scene?

RZ: Well it wasn't a thing like I — well when I got married yeah, we settled down and actually I did work for my brother, my brother was doing some stuff. My brother didn't use me first. Actually one of the first people I worked for was Pat Williams, who my brother and Pat were very close you know. And I started working for Pat. And then I called — the only phone call I ever made to try to get a gig, I called this guy, his name was Steve Carmen. He was — he used to do an act. He did a Harry Belafonte act, guitar and played you know. He worked with Bobby, accompanied Bobby a little bit, this was before I was with Bobby. And he used to say to me, "If you ever come to New York give me a call." You know. And I called him. I said, "Well Steve, how you doing?" He says, "Hey can you do a recording with me" blah blah blah "next week, we're doing a film." A cheap film. They called them nudie films, he was doing nudie films. And so he said, "Can you do this?" I said, "Sure." Then he started using me man, and he became the hottest jingle writer in New York, bar none man. He was the hottest. And I did all of his work, all of it for years. And then I worked with other people. You know I was working with — but he used to call me, his contractor would call me and give me dates way ahead of time. "Hold on to Thursday from 1 to 4; hold on to Tuesday" you know, "from 6 to 9 or something" you know. And he would give me holds and then they'd call in the date when he got it. You know. But he would hold his rhythm section.

MR: So you'd travel from one date to another in a particular day.

RZ: Oh yeah we were running man. See and what was great in those days in the 70s in New York was all the studios, most of them were close. You could walk to them. You could walk from one studio to another, or hop in a cab for just five minutes and you'd be at the next studio. You know. Everything was close. Everything was all centered in midtown you know. And then that all ended man. You know there's no studios left in New York man, I'm telling you, there's a couple of rehearsal studios. There are no recording studios man. The big rooms, Tony Bennett, the big rooms everybody recorded in, Steve and Eydie recorded, they're all gone. All those studios are gone man. They tore them down man. And there's hardly any jingle work anymore. And there used to be a ton of it. I mean I bought my first house man, with residuals. And it was like it just didn't stop. And I was young, you know, I had a lot of energy. We could run around. But that all ended, man. And then people started taking gigs on Broadway because the bands on Broadway

were not that good in the old days. Now, man, the bands on Broadway are terrific because these guys are out of work, the good players.

RM: Right.

RZ: So they're taking gigs, they're happy to get a Broadway show. Plus you get your pension built up from a Broadway show. You know.

MR: When you went in to do like a studio date most of the time you didn't know what it was for, is that correct?

RZ: Sometimes.

MR: So like a soap commercial or something like that, would you ever hear the final product like would the singers be there?

RZ: Oh yeah. Oh yeah. Well sometimes, in the old days they used to bring the singers in later to track, they'd sing to our track. We'd be leaving, packing up, and they'd come in and they'd put the singers on. But I mean Steve Carmen sent me — this jingle writer — he sent me a CD of all the stuff that I did with him.

RM: Oh my God.

RZ: Bundles of stuff. And man, we did stuff with Ella Fitzgerald, we did stuff with Satchmo, Louis Armstrong man. I mean I'm sitting there behind the drums and there's Louis. You know? Singing about tires, Goodyear Tires or something. And Ella singing some tune swinging, all swinging stuff you know but that was a highlight for me in that business was playing with them.

RM: I'll bet.

RZ: Oh man it was like, there was a thing I remember there was a scene where Louis is standing there and one of the agency people is asking Louis to play a turnaround coming out of something. And Louis is just kind of like smiling, not really saying much. And the conductor is trying to talk about it and Louis is — and finally one of the guys, nobody knew what was happening and one of the guys in the band, the trombone player yells out, he says, "Hey man that's Louis. Louis invented what you're asking for. Just let him play." And it was true man. He invented what the guy was asking for you know. And Louis — he was just so nice you know, he just did it. I remember certain players are just natural man, like John Bunch. Remember John Bunch?

RM: Yes.

MR: Yes.

RZ: John Bunch — he used to get nervous when he was on a jingle. He'd get nervous. And I remember it was me, Jay Leonhart, John Bunch, I forget who else. Small band. And Jay Leonhart did the same thing to John Bunch. He said, "Just play the way you play, man, don't let them —" you know they were asking him for things to do and he was getting nervous. Because John usually, you know he didn't do a lot of recording, he just did all

beautiful gigs you know, beautiful recordings with good singers. But Jay Leonhart saved him. I remember Jay, he says, "Hey man, just play, you know, don't listen to them."

MR: Did you ever have an ad exec hanging out in the booth trying to tell you like —

RZ: Oh yes, oh yes, yes. Yeah that's quite — it's very tricky man. It's like you know I'm going to try to do it, whatever they want, you know and it's all attitude. It's like your attitude with the person you know. It's like I honestly want to please this person. You know what I mean man? You don't run from it. You kind of like wow, let's see, I think he likes this, let me try that and that kind of thing. But nobody ever got weird or anything or indignant or anything like that you know. We always, everybody was always nice you know.

RM: How about the Copacabana recording at the Copa, tell us about how that came to be.

RZ: You know something? I wasn't even sure we were recording that night you know. It was weird man because there was always gear around, people's gear and mics and things you know, it was always around, lights. And I just played the show. It was like oh we're just playing the show. You know.

RM: But I mean I guess I didn't explain, the Barry Manilow record at the Copa?

RZ: Oh yeah, yeah, I went to California for that.

RM: Yeah. Were you with his band at the time or was that just —

RZ: No, no, it was just for the recordings. I did some recordings with him. I did some in New York and some in L.A. And Paul Shaffer was the leader and Will Lee playing bass. It was great, great players. But yeah that was some in New York and some out in L.A. And originally it started out where he wanted Copacabana to be like a Latin thing. Barry was at the piano, usually at the piano, and he'd start singing Copa Cobana [hums "Copacabana"] you know, he's singing. And I don't know it's like this, it's like that. And it was Latin. And then they hyped it up later. Then they decided, I think it was Clive Davis, they decided they wanted it strictly disco. And then they added stuff onto it. That's the way that came about. But when we originally played it it was like Latin. But that became a huge hit.

MR: Do you recall like thinking oh this is going to be a hit?

RZ: Yeah. Not particularly that record but I remember I did "Swearin' to God" with Frankie Valli and I'm playing on "Swearin' to God." That was with a big band. And I felt like that was — something was happening there you know. I really felt like it. Because actually he tracked. He sang with us but he didn't record. He sang in a booth while we recorded, which was a rehearsal for him also. And I remember it just had a groove happening. And there was a bass player on it, I forget who it was, Elliot Randall was on that. Remember Elliot Randall? Guitar player? He's on that. There was a percussionist, he's no longer with us. But this bass player, he was the bass player that you played with

that no matter what kind of music it was it felt great man. It could be a polka man. It could be a stupid — he just had a way of playing that you just knew that it was right. Like this guy just knows. And he was just a guy that did gigs around town you know, big black guy, nicest guy in the world. What the hell is his name? Gordon?

MR: Gordon Edwards?

RZ: Gordon Edwards.

MR: He was in Stuff.

RZ: You got it. Gordon Edwards that's right, that's right.

MR: Talk about a groove.

RZ: Oh man, how about that guy? And not a lot of chops. And another thing about him was he would be on a jingle or something. And a lot of jingle writers, they write out everything. And he was a natural player. And he — of course you don't ever want to give the impression that you don't know how to read you know in a situation like that. And Gordon would look at the part, "Oh yeah, yeah man, oh yeah." I mean he'd act like he was reading but he couldn't read that much. But he played the shit out of it. He played the shit out of the music, not the notes. "It's not the notes," my brother used to say, "it's the music." It's not the notes, you don't play the notes, you play the music. The difference between a great player and a mediocre. It's the music. Some of those guys, I wonder what happened to Gordon. I lost track of a lot of people man, when the business changed you know we don't see each other that much. We used to see each other on dates you know.

RM: Dolores Mancuso says you were a great impressionist.

MR: I'd like an explanation.

RZ: My father thought so too. I used to impersonate his brothers. Oh Sammy was funny man. He had a great sense of humor, Sammy.

RM: Boy he sure did.

RZ: Oh Jeez. You learn a lot from people like that man.

RM: So now Frankie Valli comes in like at the Turning Stone Casino where I used to do contracting for all the acts that came in.

RZ: Yeah, yeah.

RM: But nobody's left. And at some point everybody would come in with the computer.

RZ: Oh yeah, yeah.

RM: All right? So all the tracks, everything is on the computer. They play but at some point you know like Frankie Vallee and some of those high parts, they just push up his track and that was that. And virtually every act that came through turned in that direction.

RZ: Where was this, where was this now?

RM: At Turning Stone Casino up here.

RZ: Oh okay. Yeah, yeah.

RM: In Vernon, Verona.

RZ: I see.

RM: Big showroom and a big —

RZ: Yeah, yeah.

RM: So for years contracting those acts they would come in and play, like Aretha Franklin and like that, and little by little you'd see the computer. The drummer would have the laptop and he'd be pushing up tracks with the headphones.

RZ: You know man I bought a Linn drum machine when they first came out many years ago, because people were asking me if I programmed. Right? Do you have a machine? Could you — do you have a machine? And I'd say — so I went out and bought one you know, it was like 28 hundred dollars or something. Fantastic sounds in Linn drum machine, the old Linn. I still have it. But I would go to a date and play, and then I'd take the drum part and go home, get the machine out and try to program what I played. You know? And I did it for about two weeks and I just put it away one day man. I said I still want to play. I'm still learning how to play the drums. What am I learning now pressing buttons? It had nothing to do with our make-up as a person. And I put it away man, and then it took over. The guys that were doing dates man, you know there were a couple of mediocre drummers that bought drum machines man that made a lot of money man. And they programmed well, they did. They knew what they were doing. I'm terrible with technology man, as you know.

MR: Well we're here aren't we.

RZ: Yeah, yeah. I'm enjoying it. It's great. Great hang, man.

MR: Yeah, and some of these acts like Cher and Roberta Flack, was it a memorable experience or just one more day?

RZ: Roberta Flack was nice, yeah. That was I got to meet — oh it was a great drummer. I was on a couple of tracks and he was on another track. He's a great player, oh I forgot his name. Anyway we hung out a while. I hung out with this drummer a lot on the gig. But you know playbacks, you'd sit together and talk. But yeah, there were some great experiences man. Like you know what I got to do that I really loved man, I used to do all of Elliot Lawrence's work you know. I don't know if you remember Elliot Lawrence.

RM: Yes.

RZ: Years ago we had a jazz band, a great jazz band. Anyway he became a producer in New York and I was on everything he did. And soaps, films, he did all music and sometimes he would use Torrie, I'd see Torrie. Torrie would come in with the music. I'd say, "Oh hey man" you know. But the gigs that I did he used to take a band like you would take a rhythm section to Washington and we'd do the Kennedy Center man, you know the Kennedy Center Honors. And it was such a great gig man. And I did about five of them,

five or six of them. Clinton, Bush, who else? Reagan. Now was it, no I didn't do Reagan. I don't know if it's right. Anyway after the gig we'd go to a dinner you know and all of that. I'd take my wife you know. It was really, really a beautiful experience man. That was a great — and then he lost it, Elliot lost it. Another conductor came in. Of course they used their guys. You know. But it was a great gig. The orchestra was great you know, always. And we'd rehearse. We'd go in, we'd pre-record a lot of it there, right there you know. But that was a great gig. And we'd do the Ford Theater and there'd be a benefit for the Ford Theater every year and that was great because the president and everybody, the cabinet, you know it's a tiny theater. They were all sitting down front on top of us. We were on stage and I'm looking at Bush and this one and that one. Jeez, it was fantastic. That was fantastic. But then he lost that gig too. Everybody got older you know, we get older and new people come in and they're great. There are so many drummers around man, I can't believe it, that just blow my mind man.

RM: Yeah.

RZ: Blow my mind. I'm like how does he do that? It's amazing.

MR: Do you ever get checks in the mail and you're not sure what they're for?

RZ: That's happened to me, yes, yes. From films. Usually from films. Like I remember, oh I still get a check from what was that Spielberg movie "Close Encounters" "Close Encounters." Now get this: you remember the scene in the movie where he's building a mountain inside of his house?

MR: Yes.

RM: Yes.

RZ: And mashed potatoes and everything?

RM: Right.

RZ: There's a TV on and they're playing a Budweiser commercial that I'm on. So I get a check for like 90 bucks every once in a while, 95 bucks. At first I didn't know what it was and then I found out. Because it was weird, it was like I didn't do the film, I was just on — the TV was playing in the room while he was building a house.

RM: Beautiful man.

RZ: It's weird, isn't it? It's weird.

MR: What kind of gig do you like to play now that has sort of no pressure. Like when you're doing "Chicago" every night you just have to be so focused. What kind of gig is the total opposite of that for you?

RZ: Boy that's a good question man. Well actually I had a rehearsal band with some good arrangements and that was fun. I would call a rehearsal, I'd call up the guys, great players, everybody would always say yes I'll be there, for no money, for two hours maybe in between shows. And we'd play whatever I'd call up. I was the leader. Let's

play #23 you know. And man, like it was, after that two hours, first of all everybody always showed up. Nobody canceled or anything. I mean great players man. Bobby Porcelli, great alto player. He would get the saxophones. And man like just all great players man. And they would want to play longer. I only had the room for two hours. It was at the union by the way, which is closed, our union is closed. We're waiting for it to open so I can bring in my band again and rehearse. Because they have a great room with drums and, you know, not only me everybody wants to do it. But then I would play with other bands too, rehearsal bands, that was fun. There was no pressure. You know you're sight reading but it doesn't matter. There's no audience you're just by yourselves playing. There might be a few people hanging out. But that was fun. But to tell you the truth man I want to go on a gig and play some tunes man. I just want to play "All the Things You Are." You know. I mean you know I just want to play some tunes man, good tunes. Just ding-ding-a-ding.

MR: Come on up to Utica and we'll play some dang-dang-a-dang.

RZ: I'm telling you man it's amazing. But I'll tell you man my chops are so strange now from playing the show, I have a lot of bad habits because of the way I'm set up, things like that, and I've got some arthritis coming in you know. But I can still play the show, and play pretty strong yet you know. Fast — "Caldonia" is over for me. I did that with Woody for two years and "Northwest Passage" [scats] it was crazy. Woody wanted everything fast. That's a great band leader. Woody was a great band leader. Great guy man. Boy, miss him. And I did five albums with him. The first album was "My Kind of Broadway." We did all these Broadway tunes. And he had charts in there from Bill Holman and oh Nat Pierce did a lot, all good music, very good music. And then —

MR: Was it "Live in Antibes" that you did?

RZ: Pardon me?

MR: Was it, there's a live thing you did —

RZ: Oh yeah, Antibes. Yeah, yeah. That's right. We didn't get paid for that for a long time. Yeah we did that and that's about it, but Woody was a great experience for me. See that's another thing, when I got off of Woody's band and I came to New York let's get that guy that was with Woody. That's the way it went man. It just does. They hear you, they're playing a Woody Herman record on the radio locally on the jazz station. Other musicians hear it and — I was getting gigs just because I was with Woody. Actually I got more mileage out of Woody than Bobby Darin. You know? In other words because the musicians were more impressed, and the writers, with somebody from Woody's band than with Bobby I guess. You know. I don't know. Although they loved Bobby and some of his stuff was great. He did want to swing all the time. He was right on it man. You know I used to do this thing at the Three Rivers Inn with him, I don't do it anymore

because I'm not playing that kind of music that much. You know when the drummer sneaks in? You know when you're playing and you sneak in soft-soft-soft-soft. He never heard that man. He flipped over it. And after a while he'd go, [whispers] "Sneak in, sneak in," you know while he's on stage. You know I wouldn't be playing and he'd go "Sneak in, sneak in, man, sneak in." And then just soft cymbal, just soft cymbal, and even no hi-hat man. Then all of a sudden a little hi-hat, maybe cross stick you know. He went nuts over that. It was stuff that I heard in the jazz records man, all the stuff we listened to, you know, Blakey and Philly Joe.

RM: Who were your biggest influences in terms of drummers?

RZ: Oh man, well Philly Joe really and "Billy Boy" man, you know, listen to that one. What's wrong with that? "Billy Boy" man. And Art Blakey man, in the very beginning Art Blakey was just thundering. And Kenny Clarke man. Brushes? Kenny Clarke, what a player man. I loved Billy Higgins though too. Billy Higgins. And Buddy. I was on the phone with Frank DeVito last night, my cousin who is a drummer from Utica and he's like 90 now, 91. We were talking about, every once in a while we talk about Buddy Rich. You have to.

RM: Right.

RZ: You just have to. And we were talking about Buddy's — well you know certain things he did man — the feel he got where other people tried doing it in that era and they couldn't quite do it like he could do it. He was like a magician man. And he never, he never messed up man. He never got hung up on anything, no matter what he tried to play he could play. It was just like a miracle man, to watch it. And Frank, he was pretty good friends with him. And Buddy, he was a character man. And he was over at Frank's house one day and Frank has got a pair of drumsticks on the coffee table, right? And so Frank says, "Hey Buddy, what is that, what is that you do there?" Buddy picks up the sticks, "What are you talking about?" And you know Buddy was crass. So Frank tells me he picks up the sticks and he starts playing all this shit on the coffee table. It blew his mind. It was just paradiddles [scats]. He was like he just tossed it like it was nothing. And I got a kick out of that story.

MR: Well Ronnie, I've got a kick out of this hang.

RM: Hey one thing, if I don't say hello from Pete Procopio I'm going to be —

RZ: Oh man, yeah you too, please say hello to him for me.

RM: Yes I will.

RZ: Yeah Pete. There was a trumpet player in the band, Glenn Drewes

RM: Glenn, sure.

RZ: Did you know Glenn?

RM: Yes, yes, yes, and that band he —

RZ: He does a lot of stuff in New York. He's the lead trumpet player in the show I'm doing. And every once in a while he calls Pete up and puts me on the phone, once in a while when we're having a couple of drinks you know. And the last conversation I had with him I ended it with, "Pete I can't play fast anymore man." He says, "Who wants to play fast?" he says. You know you get, it's like after Woody man I got to the point where I could play real fast you know, and when you don't, if you don't do it you lose it.

RM: Right.

RZ: Well this has been great.

MR: Thank you.

RM: I agree.

RZ: Really easy to talk to man and great questions too man.

MR: So it's a gas having you two together at the same time.

RZ: Oh I love this, yeah, the way you set this up, this is beautiful.

RM: Thank you, Monk.

MR: Thank you.

RZ: Well thank you.

MR: Terrific. I'm going to pause our recording here and then we'll say good-bye.

RZ: Okay.

MR: All right.

RZ: So I'll just sit where I'm at, right?

MR: You're good.

RM: We're good.